



IT HURTS

A tech job offers youngsters everything in a jiffy—money, power, status—but deprives them the luxury of time, taking a toll on their health and well-being

■ **By Swagata Sen**

Outside the metropolis, Bangalore's information technology (IT) professionals carry an enviable image: fat salaries, perks in plenty, snazzy, hi-tech offices, frequent travel, global exposure, fancy apartments and cars. In short, the great Indian dream. Or is it? Scratch the surface and there are disturbing signs that life in Silicon City is taking a heavy toll. In the first survey of its kind conducted among IT professionals, at least 36 per cent of the respondents can

be classified as probable psychiatric cases while 10 per cent report severe mental distress. The survey was conducted in December 2007 by the National Institute for Mental Health and Neurosciences (NIMHANS) and four other medical outfits. A 30 per cent rate of psychiatric morbidity is high by any standards—the survey notes that the prevalence rate among the general population in the country is as low as 58.2 per 1,000.

Welcome to the world of IT employees. You don't really know which country you'll inhabit in a week's time and

when they say flexi-time at work, they mean an hour late to office the next day because you thrashed out a deal with a client five hours behind 1st the entire night before. And then, there are the impossible deadlines, the constant guilt of unmet demands by spouse and family and the fear of the pink slip.

While India's Silicon Valley sees 20- and 30-something *lakhpatitis* driving C-segment cars and paying EMIs that constitute government employees' annual salaries, there is another side to the story. A side where 28 per cent say they are constantly under strain, 22 per